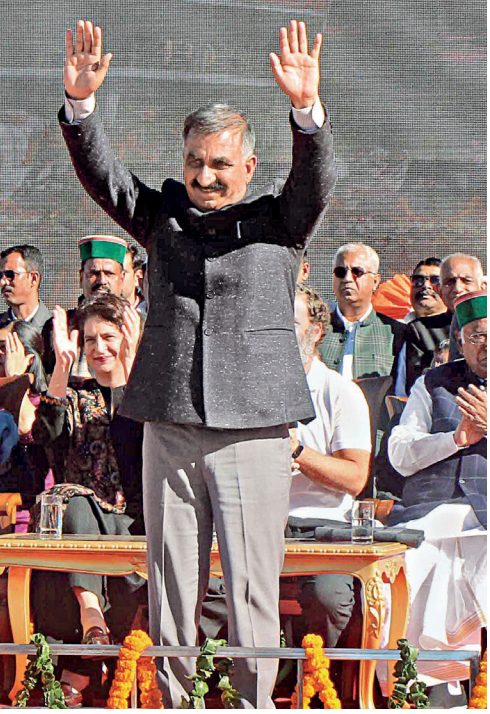


BOY FROM DOWNHILL
Sukhu, son of a bus driver, is a grassroots worker risen to the top

Another area of disquiet it must settle has to do with the apple farmers, who have taken to the streets this year after a gap of three decades. Agitated over rising input costs and dwindling profits, they are angry over the enhanced GST on apple boxes and the declining prices offered by big private players for their produce—down by a third from around Rs 90 per kg two years ago. The Congress had guaranteed during its poll campaign that fruit growers in the state will get to decide the price of their produce. Any lag on that will be perceived as a pro-market tilt and a betrayal by the farmers.

The third big challenge is internal, and it remains to be seen how skilful Sukhu will be in negotiating that. Factionalism within the party came out in the open soon after the election results were announced on December 8, with followers of the Pratibha Singh camp openly canvassing for her CM candidacy—especially since the demise of the popular Virbhadra had pulled in votes. Once the high command chose to elevate him, though, Sukhu has made light of it, and has moved to smooth ruffled feathers by saying Pratibha's son Vikramaditya Singh would be inducted in the cabinet.

"In the first cabinet meeting, we will implement two guarantees, including restoration of OPS," Sukhu told the media. The Congress had announced 10 guarantees: besides OPS, these included Rs 1,500 monthly financial assistance for eligible women, and creating 500,000 jobs. Overall, he seems to be in mission mode for now. A lot of this has to do with the tireless political journey he has charted. Born on March 27, 1964, in Sera Bhabran village, Hamirpur district, Sukhu's political stint began with the NSUI—he was president of the Congress's student wing from 1988 to 1995. A lawyer by training, he graduated full-time to politics after being elected as a councillor in the Shimla Municipal Corporation in 1992. He was also the state Youth Congress president from 1998 to 2008, the year he became the state party's general secretary, graduating to serve as PCC chief in 2013-19.

In a state where politics has often been dominated by patricians, the four-time MLA is a rare grassroots worker who has risen to the top. In what is almost a visual metaphor for that, he's also the first Congress CM from the lower merged areas of Himachal—all his forebears hailed from the upper belt. As a college student, Sukhu had worked on the side in the complaint office of the State Electricity Board. That common touch will be crucial as the Congress seeks to rediscover its appeal. ■

By Prashant Srivastava

The results to the three bypolls in Uttar Pradesh have brought several positives for the Samajwadi Party (SP)-led Opposition—despite their upset loss in Rampur Sadar—and given much to reflect over for the ruling BJP, which may now have to rethink its 2024 strategy. The 288,000-plus victory margin for Dimple Yadav in the Mainpuri Lok Sabha seat has left it in shock—it was expecting at least a close fight in the SP bastion, if not a second upset win. Even the late Mulayam Singh Yadav, four-time MP from here, had won only with 93,000-odd votes in 2019. Says SP spokesperson Dr Ashutosh Verma, "The BJP had claimed that by fielding a Shakya candidate, it would get all non-Yadav OBC votes. However, even Shakya voters supported us."

This turn to events was imparted mainly by the ghar wapasi of Shivpal Yadav. For long troubled by the monopoly of his nephew Akhilesh Yadav over Samajwadi affairs, the uncle had finally split in 2018, forming the Pragatisheel Samajwadi Party (Lohia). Thereafter, the SP slipped downhill in state politics, losing election after election. Mulayam's demise in October brought renewed efforts at a patch-up: Dimple-Akhilesh met Shivpal at his residence in a much-photographed event, seeking blessings for the 'bahu'. Shivraj acceded, and went on to play a huge role in the campaign. In fact, Dimple got her highest vote lead (over 100,000) from Shivpal's Jaswant Nagar assembly segment. That done, Shivpal merged his PSPL with the Akhilesh-led SP.

Says political analyst Pankaj Kumar, a professor at Allahabad University, "Both needed each other at this point. Shivpal has a strong hold in organisational politics and connections across parties. Now it depends on Akhilesh, how he utilises him." The BJP-led alliance hold 65 seats out of UP's 80 Lok Sabha seats and Kumar thinks the reunification may set up some interesting contests in 2024.

Another reason for that: how the Opposition took Khatauli from the BJP, with an interesting experiment that could trouble the latter. Jayant Chaudhary's RLD, a party that predominantly represents the Jats, this time fielded a Gujjar, Madan Bhaiya. That it worked is quite significant. The two communities have never much been on the same page before. Jayant's efforts at joining them, with reasonably assured Muslim support adding ballast to it, thus breaks a pattern.

BEYOND MAINPURI, THE RLD'S KHATAULI WIN WAS POWERED BY A NEW ALLIANCE: JATS, GUJJARS, MUSLIMS, DALITS

Later, the RLD also got the support of Azad Samaj Party chief Chandrashekhar Azad. This way, a section of Dalit voters too come close to the SP-RLD alliance. Talking to INDIA TODAY, Jayant affirms the positives. "The support of Bhim Army chief Chandrashekhar was one of the key factors in our strategy working. The message from Khatauli has gone out to the whole sugarcane belt of UP, where the government has not fulfilled the expectations of farmers." He also says the results show Muzaffarnagar (within which Khatauli falls) is shedding the Hindu-Muslim animus that has defined the region's politics after the 2013 riots. An RLD leader says the new combination "accounts for over 40 per cent votes in a dozen-odd districts of west UP".

The only positive for the BJP came in Rampur, where it defeated Azam Khan aide Asim Raza of the SP with a margin of 34,136 votes—a result that shows a drift of sections of the Muslim vote towards the saffron party. Still, the party has plenty to worry about. ■